

# Echoes of Reason

## Official Rules and Regulations

### Ground Rules

1. No religion or theology, ever. Instant disqualification. No appeal.
2. All claims must be scientifically grounded. A fabricated or illogical claim stands unless the opposing team catches it (via cross-questioning or a later speech); if caught and fabricated, the argument is disregarded.
3. No hate speech or discrimination. Instant disqualification. No appeal.
4. Respect the room. Inattention is fine; disruptive audible noise gets a formal warning.
5. Judges' decisions are final. Feedback may be requested after the round, not contested in-room.
6. Rounds begin at approximately 2:15 PM.
7. **No printed material of any kind.** Speakers may bring one page of **handwritten, bullet-point notes only** (no full sentences/paragraphs), capped at **75 words per speaker**. Phones and other devices are surrendered before each round.

Penalty (Rule 7): violating notes are confiscated on sight for the rest of the debate; a repeat offence by the same speaker costs a Method score penalty.

### Format

Modified Asian Parliamentary format — 2 teams of 3 speakers, no coalitions, judged by appointed judges only (no public voting). 4 rounds across 2 days, single-elimination: **Round 1** Qualifier, **Round 2** Qualifier, **Round 3** Seminal, **Round 4** Grand Final. Winners of Rounds 1 & 2 advance to the Seminal; Grand Final sides are set by a live coin toss shortly before the debate.

### Speaker Roles, Timing & Job

| # | Role         | Speak | Q&A | Reply | Job                                             |
|---|--------------|-------|-----|-------|-------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | PM (Prop)    | 3m    | 1m  | 1m    | Define the motion. Build Prop's opening case.   |
| 2 | LO (Opp)     | 3m    | 1m  | 1m    | Rebut PM. Build Opp's counter-case.             |
| 3 | DPM (Prop)   | 3m    | 1m  | 1m    | Rebut LO. Defend and extend Prop's case.        |
| 4 | DLO (Opp)    | 3m    | 1m  | 1m    | Rebut DPM. Defend and extend Opp's case.        |
| 5 | Opp Closing  | 3m    | —   | —     | Summarise & weigh the debate. No new arguments. |
| 6 | Prop Closing | 3m    | —   | —     | Summarise & weigh. No new arguments. Last word. |

Total speaking time per debate: 4×5 min (speech + Q&A + reply) + 2×3 min closings = **26 minutes**.

### Role Details

#### PM (Prop)

- Define the motion — clear, reasonable, not rigged either way.
- Set the framework for the round.
- Present at least two developed arguments (opening case).

#### LO (Opp)

- Respond to the PM; challenge the definition if unreasonable.
- Rebut the Proposition's case point by point.
- Build Opposition's own independent case.

#### DPM (Prop)

- Rebut the LO point by point.
- Defend the PM's arguments against attack.
- Extend Prop's case with new material.

#### DLO (Opp)

- Rebut the DPM.
- Defend the LO's case.
- Extend Opposition's case further.

#### Opp Closing

- No new arguments.
- Summarise the whole debate from Opposition's side.
- Weigh the key clashes; explain why Opposition wins each.

#### **Prop Closing**

- No new arguments.
- Mirror the Opposition Closing, favouring Proposition.
- Delivered last — gets the final word.

#### **Cross-Questioning (replaces Points of Information)**

- After each of the four main speeches (PM, LO, DPM, DLO), the **opposing team gets 1 minute** to question the speaker.
- Any of the three opposing teammates may ask questions, but **only one may speak at a time** — no overlapping or simultaneous questioning.
- The original speaker then gets **1 minute to reply**, uninterrupted.
- **No cross-questioning during the Closing speeches** (Opp Closing, Prop Closing) — these run straight through with no interruption.
- Whether the full minute must be used or time can be ceded early, and any penalty for speaking out of turn during the Q&A or reply window, is **at the judges' discretion** on the day.

#### **Building an Argument**

Every argument needs all three: **Claim** (what you assert), **Warrant** (why it's true — evidence, logic, data), **Impact** (why it matters to the debate). Two or three fully developed arguments beat five shallow ones every time.

#### **How You Are Judged**

Judges score each speaker 50–100 (baseline 75) across five criteria: **Matter** (argument quality/depth), **Manner** (clarity; accents ignored), **Method** (role fulfilment), **Engagement** (rebuttal quality & cross-questioning participation), **Impact Calculus** (weighing harms/benefits). Judges vote as an ordinary intelligent voter: smart, fair-minded, no specialist knowledge, no bias.